Twelve Things to Notice About How the Work of Your Husband's Care Is Getting Done This Week

Plain things to notice and jot down about dates, tasks and who is doing what, before anyone puts them in order.

This week the work of your husband's care is coming at you from several directions: the hospital, the rehab, the pharmacy, the family. Before anyone sits down to put it in order, it helps to have a few days of plain notes about how that work is actually getting done.

Notice and record. Don't sort it out yet, and don't decide what any of it says about your family. The habit of writing down what you're told, and who told you, follows Medicare's discharge checklist and the Family Caregiver Alliance. The twelve items and the wording about what to write are ours.

Dates and the people waiting

1 Dates you've been given [1]

NOTICE Each date somebody has said out loud: the discharge, an answer the rehab is waiting for, an appointment.

WRITE DOWN The date, who gave it, and the day they told you.

2 Dates the family is working to

NOTICE A “by Friday” that everyone repeats and nobody outside the family ever said.

WRITE DOWN The date, the word “assumed,” and who could confirm it.

3 Who is waiting on you

NOTICE The people who have asked you for something this week: the rehab, the pharmacy, a relative with a list.

WRITE DOWN What each one asked for, in their words, and whether they said by when.

Choices and what they wait on

4 The choices on the list

NOTICE Which items are choices someone has to make, as distinct from chores and things to find out.

WRITE DOWN Each choice on its own line. Don't make it yet.

5 What a choice is waiting on

NOTICE A choice that keeps stalling because something else isn't known yet.

WRITE DOWN The two items together: the one that waits, and the one it waits on.

6 What your husband has said he wants [3]

NOTICE Anything he has said, directly or in passing, about what matters to him in what comes next.

WRITE DOWN His words, with the day. Keep them separate from what the family wants.

Questions and answers

7 Questions still open [2]

NOTICE A question that has been asked aloud more than once and hasn't been written down anywhere.

WRITE DOWN The question, and whose it is to answer: the family, his doctor or nurse, the pharmacist, the discharge planner or social worker.

8 What you've been told, and by whom [4]

NOTICE Instructions given in a hallway or over the phone, and whether you also have them in writing.

WRITE DOWN What was said, who said it and the day. Ask for it in writing.

Who is doing what

9 Whose name goes with each task

NOTICE Who did each thing this week: the calls, the driving, the forms, the trips to the pharmacy.

WRITE DOWN A name beside each task as it was done, not as it was meant to be done.

10 Offers of help [5]

NOTICE Anyone who has said “let me know what I can do,” and what they offered.

WRITE DOWN The person and the offer, in their words. Don't put their name on a task until they've said yes to it.

11 Tasks with no name, and tasks with only one

NOTICE Things everyone assumes someone else is handling, and important things only one person knows how to do.

WRITE DOWN The task, and “nobody yet” or “only me.”

You

12 How you are doing [6] [4]

NOTICE Your own sleep, how tired you are, whether you feel overwhelmed or alone with this.

WRITE DOWN A line a day, in plain words. It's something to mention to your own doctor, and to the hospital staff when they ask what you're able to do.

When a note isn't enough

This page is about the work around your husband's care, not about his health. If something about his condition, his medicines or his safety worries you, it doesn't belong in these notes. Tell his nurse or his doctor. Medicare's discharge checklist tells families to write down the names and phone numbers of people to call with questions or concerns. If you don't have those yet, ask the staff for them.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these notes mean, who ought to be doing more, or what order things belong in. It gives you a few days of plain facts to bring to the conversation where that gets worked out.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed how the week is really going and written it down. The care interview does the same for your husband's whole situation: it walks you through it area by area, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
2. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
3. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
6. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine, NIH), Caregiver Health